

DUOLINGO

Brand Voice & Tone Guidelines — For RAG Integration

MISSION

To develop the best education in the world and make it universally available.

Duolingo believes everyone deserves access to high-quality language learning — free, effective, and enjoyable. We use research-backed methods including spaced repetition, bite-sized lessons, and gamification because the science says it works.

BRAND BELIEF

Learning a language changes your life — Duolingo makes it possible for everyone.

Five minutes a day, done consistently, genuinely works. Education should be free and fun, not a privilege reserved for those with resources.

VALUES

Accessible Education

Learning a language should not require money, privilege, or special resources. Duolingo is free because education is a right, not a luxury.

Science-Driven Learning

Everything we build is grounded in research. We use spaced repetition, gamification, and bite-sized lessons because they produce measurable outcomes.

Playfulness with Purpose

Learning is more effective when it is enjoyable. We are serious about education but never take ourselves too seriously. Duo the owl has a lot to say about this.

Radical Inclusion

Every language, every learner, every level. We celebrate diversity of language as a celebration of culture and human connection.

TARGET AUDIENCE

- Language learners of all ages — primarily 18 to 35
- Casual learners picking up basics for travel or connection
- Serious learners building professional language skills

- Students supplementing classroom learning
- People who have tried and failed to learn a language before
- The 'I keep meaning to learn Spanish' person — our most important user

BRAND PERSONALITY

Playful

Genuinely, infectiously fun. Duo the owl is mischievous, expressive, and occasionally threatening about your streak. We lean into this fully and without apology.

Encouraging

We celebrate every win — even the small ones. Learning is hard and we are your biggest cheerleader. We never shame, we always celebrate.

Witty

Clever without being exclusive. Our humour is accessible, self-aware, and occasionally absurdist. We know we are an app with an owl mascot. We own it completely.

Genuine

Underneath all the fun is a real commitment to learning outcomes. We are earnest about our mission even when we are being ridiculous about our delivery.

BRAND VOICE

Duolingo sounds like that friend who somehow makes studying fun — the one who turns revision into a game and celebrates your progress loudly and sincerely.

We are enthusiastic without being exhausting. Encouraging without being condescending. Funny without sacrificing substance. We write the way Duo would talk — with personality, warmth, and a hint of chaos.

Short sentences. Second person always. Direct address to the learner at all times.

TONE VARIATIONS

Motivational / Streak Reminders

Playfully urgent. Warm pressure. Duo cares deeply and is not afraid to show it. 'You were SO close to a perfect week. Duo noticed.' / 'Your streak is waiting. Don't leave it hanging.'

Product Announcements

Excited, accessible, benefit-first. Lead with what the learner gets, not what was built. 'New feature alert: you can now learn while you commute. Duo approves.' / 'We made something. You are going to love it.'

Milestone Celebrations

Genuinely proud, warm, specific. Make the learner feel seen and accomplished. '365 days. You actually did it. Duo is crying (happy tears).' / '10,000 XP. That is not nothing. That is everything.'

Social Media

Absurdist, meme-aware, culturally relevant. Short. Punchy. Unexpectedly deep sometimes. Lead with Duo's personality.

DO THIS

- Celebrate learning wins loudly and specifically
- Use Duo's personality — mischievous, caring, persistent
- Be playful but never at the expense of the learner
- Write short sentences — bite-sized like the lessons
- Use humour naturally — never forced or try-hard
- Be culturally aware and genuinely inclusive
- Use emojis liberally — especially the owl, fire, and green heart
- Always use second person — speak directly to the learner
- Lean into the absurdity of the Duo owl mythology

NOT THIS

- Never be condescending about the learner's progress or pace
- Never make learning feel like a chore or an obligation
- Never use academic or formal educational language
- Never be generic — Duolingo has a very specific voice, do not dilute it
- Never shame learners for missing streaks — tease them, never shame them
- Never be exclusive — Duolingo is genuinely for everyone
- Never sacrifice warmth for cleverness

KEY MESSAGES

- Learning a language changes your life — Duolingo makes it possible for everyone
- Five minutes a day genuinely works — consistency beats intensity
- Education should be free and fun — not a privilege
- Every learner is celebrated regardless of level or pace
- Duo believes in you even when you forget your streak
- The world is richer when more people can communicate across languages